



DATA GLUT

Way back in 1981, Bill Gates apparently said that 640 kB was more than enough for anybody. Today, you can fill up that space in less than the time it takes to blink...

Rossi Fernandes

There is an interesting theory that the human race is akin to a gas — in that it expands to take up all available space. One only needs to look around to identify at least a kernel of truth in that proposition. Much like us, data is pervasive and tends to be omnipresent. In many ways, our data is a reflection of ourselves — it's plentiful, varied, and present like a shadow sticking to our connected race. Today, a cross-section of the world wide web, that prime example of our society's data glut, is as likely to carry data from a star dead a million years ago, as it might carry your first-born's first giggle. As data explodes into our senses, data storage lags our needs, as perhaps all technology does. Why don't we have holographic storage devices yet, or better yet, those cool crystals that Superman employs to store his race's collective blog? Why are we still juggling data around across various media, partitions, and systems? Wouldn't it be great if we could just pluck data from the sky; heedless of where it might be, or how much of it, or of what kind? Small progress has been made though; as economy of scale and production would allow — solid-state drives (SSD) are maturing quickly and have gone from novel marketing ammunition to products that us real consumers might pick up and use in our daily lives. They are a threat to the traditional hard drives for sure, and form a product category to be taken seriously in the very near future. The only area SSDs lack today is storage capacity. Hard drive manufacturers are pushing storage capacities to the limits. Disk densities have gone up significantly. Today, a 2 TB drive is more or less common. One terabyte is affordable, with 500- and 640 GB drives becoming a bare minimum for any PC, even if you think you don't need it. And you do.

Portable storage is another area of progress, however small. Large amounts of data have to be moved easily and safely, and portable drives and external desktop storage drives fill that space and requirement. These have advanced and in many ways become generic in their performance and features, so much so that manufacturers aren't just focussing on connectivity and features anymore. Data security and backup is now the key focus. For modern networked homes with multiple computing devices and home-theatre systems, network-capable drives are a requirement as well. We've rounded up a bunch of these devices and put them to the test.

Photographed by: Manas Parekh